§ **56.** Umlaut generally did not take place before Germanic consonant combinations, as **dwæscan,** *to extinguish*; **æsc** from ***askiz,** *ash-tree*; **æspe,** *aspen*; **fæstan,** *to fasten*; **hæftan,** *to hold captive*; **mæstan,** *to fatten*; **næglan,** *to nail*; **ræscan,** *to coruscate.* But umlaut occurs in **eft,** *again*; **esne,** *servant*; **rest,** *rest*; **restan,** *to rest*; and in **efnan,** *to perform*; **stefnan,** *to regulate,* beside **æfnan, stæfnan.**

§ **57.** Germanic **a** remained in open syllables when originally followed by a guttural vowel (ă, ŏ, ŭ) in the next syllable, as pl. nom. acc. **dagas,** gen. **daga,** dat. **dagum,** beside sing. nom. **dæg,** *day*; gen. **dæges,** dat. **dæge**; neut. nom. acc. plural **baþu,** *baths*; **bladu,** *leaves* **fatu,** *vats,* beside singular **bæþ, blæd, fæt**; OE. Goth. OS. OHG. **faran,** O.Icel. **fara,** *to go, travel*; **nacod,** Goth. **naqaþs,** OHG. **nackot,** *naked*; and similarly **alan,** *to nourish*; **apa,** *ape*; **bacan,** *to bake*; **calan,** *to be cold*; **caru,** *care*; **cradol,** *cradle*; **dragan,** *to draw*; pres. subj. **fare** (Goth. **farái**), *he may travel*; **gaderian** from ***gađurōjan,** *to gather*; **galan,** *to sing*; **gnagan,** *to gnaw*; **grafan,** *to dig*; **hafoc,** *hawk*; **hafola, hafela,** *head*; **hagol,** *hail*; **hagu,** *enclosure*; **hara,** *hare*; **hladan,** *to load*; **hraþor,** *more quickly*; **lagu,** *law*; **latost,** *latest, slowest*; **laþaþ,** *he invites*; **laþode,** *he invited*; **macaþ,** *he makes*; **macode,** *he made*; **magu,** *boy*; **nafula, nafela,** *navel*; **racu,** *narrative*; **sacan,** *to quarrel*; **sacu,** *strife*; **sadol,** *saddle*; **stapol,** *pillar*; **staþelian** from ***staþulōjan,** *to establish*; **talu,** *statement*; **wadan,** *to go, wade.* **macian** from ***makōjan,** *to make*; and similarly in the inf. of other weak verbs belonging to class II (§ **535**), as **baþian,** *to bathe*; **dagian,** *to dawn*; **gladian,** *to be glad*; **hatian,** *to hate*; **laþian,** *to invite.*

It also remained in closed syllables before double consonants (except **hh**), **sc,** and **st,** when the next syllable originally contained a guttural vowel, as **abbod** (Lat. acc.

abbātem), *abbot*; **assa**, *donkey*; **catte** (OHG. **kazza**), *cat*; **cassuc**, *sedge*; **gaffetung**, *scoffing*; **habban** (§ 538), *to have*; **hassuc**, *coarse grass*; **maffa**, *caul*; **mattoc**, *mattock*; **sacc**, *sack*; **þaccian**, *to flap, pat*; **flasce** (**flaxe**), *flask*; **masc** (**max**), *net*; **wascan** (**waxan**), *to wash*; **brastlian**, *to crackle*. But a few words have **æ** beside **a**, as **æsce**, *ash, cinders*; **æppel**, *apple*; **hnæppian**, *to doze*; **læppa**, *lappet*, beside **asce** (**axe**), **appla**, *apples*, **hnappian**, **lappa**.

NOTE.—**sca-** was often written **scea-** with **e** to denote the palatal pronunciation of the **sc**, as **sceacan**, *to shake*; **sceadu**, *shadow*; **sceafan**, *to shave*; **scealu**, *scale* (*balance*); **sceamu** (**sceomu**, § 59), *shame*, beside **scacan**, **scadu**, **scafan**, **scalu**, **scamu** (**scomu**). See § 51, Note.

§ 58. **a** became **æ** when followed by an umlauted vowel in the next syllable, as **æces** (**æx**) from ***akysi**, older ***akusi-**, *axe*; and similarly **æþele** from ***aþali** (OS. **ađali**), *noble*; **æþeling** from ***aþuling**, *nobleman*; **æt-**, **tō-gædere** from ***-gađuri**, *together*; **fæsten** (OS. **fastunnia**, *fasting*), *fortress*; **gædeling** (OS. **gaduling**), *companion*; **hæleþ** from ***χaluþi-**, *hero*; **hærfest** from ***χarubist**, *harvest*; **mægden** from ***maʒađīn** (OHG. **magatīn**), *maiden*. The **æ** in the above examples is a kind of umlaut.

NOTE.—The **a** in the stem-syllable of the present participle and gerund of strong verbs belonging to class VI (§ 508) is due to the **a** of the infinitive, as **farende** for ***færende** from ***farandi**, **farenne** for ***færenne** from ***farannjai**.

§ 59. Germanic **a** was probably a mid-back-wide vowel like the **a** in German **Mann**. In OE. it became a low-back-wide vowel before nasals like the **â** in French **pâte**, and the **a** as pronounced in many Scotch dialects in such words as **ant**, **man**, **pass**, which English people often mistake for **o** especially when lengthened. In the oldest OE. it was nearly always written **a**, in the ninth century it was mostly written **o**, and in late OE. mostly **a** again, but

in some parts of Mercia it seems to have become **o** which has been preserved in many of the Midland dialects down to the present day. Examples are: **gangan, gongan,** Goth. **gaggan,** O.Icel. **ganga,** OS. OHG. **gangan,** *to go*; **hana, hona,** Goth. **hana,** O.Icel. **hane,** OS. OHG. **hano,** *cock*; **lang, long,** Goth. **laggs,** O.Icel. **langr,** OS. OHG. **lang,** *long*; **nama, noma,** Goth. **namō,** OS. OHG. **namo,** *name*; and similarly **ancor** (Lat. **ancora**), *anchor*; **bana,** *slayer*; **brand,** *firebrand*; **camb,** *comb*; **camp,** *battle*; **candel** (Lat. **candēla**), *candle*; **cann,** *he can*; **fana,** *banner*; **gandra,** *gander*; **gesamnian,** *to collect*; **hamor,** *hammer*; **hand,** *hand*; **lama,** *lame*; **lamb,** *lamb*; **land,** *land*; **manig** (Goth. **manags**), *many*; **mann,** *man*; **ramm,** *ram*; **spannan,** *to clasp, fasten*; **standan,** *to stand*; **strang,** *strong*; **þanc,** *thought*; **þwang,** *thong*; in the pret. singular of many strong verbs of class III (§ 498), as **begann,** *began*; **dranc,** *drank*; **fand,** *found*; **sang,** *sang*; **swamm,** *swam*; with metathesis of **r** in **born** from older **bronn, brann** (Goth. **brann**), *burned*; **orn** from older **ronn, rann** (Goth. **rann**), *ran*.

NOTE.—The **a** became **o** in unstressed adverbial and pronominal forms, as **hwonne,** *when*; **on,** *on*; **þonne,** *then*; masc. acc. singular **hwone,** *whom*; **þone,** *the*.

§ 60. **a** (**o**) became **e** (but **æ** in the oldest period) by i-umlaut, as **ende,** Goth. **andeis,** O.Icel. **ende,** OS. **endi,** OHG. **enti,** stem **andja-,** *end*; **lengra,** OS. **lengira,** OHG. **lengiro,** *longer*; **sendan,** Goth. **sandjan,** OS. **sendian,** *to send*; and similarly **benc** from ***baŋkiz,** *bench*; **cemban,** *to comb*; **cempa,** *warrior*; **drencan,** *to give to drink*; **ened,** *duck*; **enge,** *narrow*; **englisc,** *English*; **fremman,** *to perform*; **henn,** *hen*; **lengþ,** *length*; **menn,** *men*; **mengan,** *to mix*; **mennisc,** *human*; **nemnan,** *to name*; **pening,** *penny*; **strengra,** *stronger*; **þencan,** *to think*; **wendan,** *to turn*. **bærnan** (Goth. **brannjan**), *to burn*; **ærnan** (Goth.